

FIRES ALL AROUND
Video grab of violence in Kangpokpi district on Sept. 19

40+ KILLED

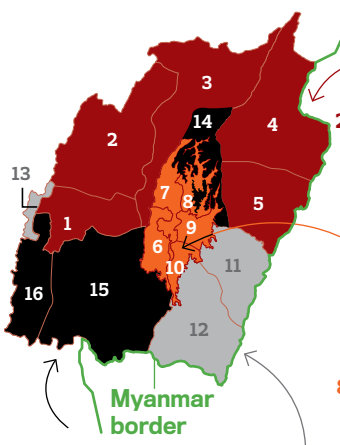
100-odd houses torched in Naga-Kuki Zo clashes since the BJP regime led by CM Yumnam Khemchand Singh took office on Feb. 4

ancestral land. Kuki organisations saw it as a vital lifeline necessitated by the ethnic cleaving that followed the 2023 violence. A faction of the Zeliangrong United Front, a political/militant organisation of the Zeliangrong Naga community, also burnt some structures allegedly linked to illegal poppy cultivation.

Then, on May 13, three Kuki-Zo church leaders travelling from Churachandpur to Kangpokpi were killed in an ambush. They included Rev. Vumthang Sitlhou, a respected Baptist leader and an intermediary for Naga-Kuki reconciliation. Responsibility for the attack has still not been fixed. Kuki organisations blamed the Nagas; the latter denied the allegation and demanded an investigation. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) is now investigating the ambush.

Within days, abductions began on both sides, though most of the captives were eventually exchanged or released. But six Naga men did not return. Their bodies were recovered on June 10. The Kuki-Zo Council later described the killings as a "grave mistake", while simultaneously denying that they had been authorised by the community leadership.

MANIPUR'S RED LINES



NAGA AREAS
1. Noney
2. Tamenglong
3. Senapati
4. Ukhrul
5. Kamjong

MEITEI AREAS
6. Bishnupur
7. Imphal East
8. Imphal West
9. Thoubal
10. Kakching

KUKI AREAS
14. Kangpokpi
15. Churachandpur
16. Pherzwal

MIXED POPULATION
11. Tengnoupal
12. Chandel
13. Jiribam